

The Airbnb & STR Setup Checklist

Everything that goes into a short-term rental that photographs beautifully, books consistently, and earns five-star reviews — with our recommendations for each step. Print it, work through it, and check off as you go.

How to use this: Move through the eight stages in order. The notes under each stage are our quick recommendations; the boxes are your to-dos. For our full, specific picks and reusable planning templates, see the guide link at the end.

Want more than the basics? This checklist is the free head start. Our complete **Airbnb & STR Design Guide** on Etsy goes deeper on every section — with specific product recommendations, sourcing lists, and **fillable templates** you can reuse for every property.

01 Plan the Space First

Great rentals are designed backward from the guest. Decide who you're hosting and the nightly rate you're targeting, then design to it. Map furniture to real room dimensions *before* you buy anything — the most common (and expensive) mistake is buying pieces that don't fit the space or the photos.

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| ☐ Define your ideal guest and target nightly rate | ☐ Set a maximum occupancy and design to it |
| ☐ Measure every room; plan layout, flow, and sightlines | ☐ Maximize comfortable sleeping without overcrowding |
| ☐ Choose one cohesive style & palette that photographs well | ☐ Plan for durability — a working rental, not a home |

Drift tip: Sleeping capacity sells — but never at the expense of comfort. A cramped listing earns cramped reviews.

02 Furnish for Durability & Photos

Every piece pulls double duty: it has to survive constant turnover *and* look incredible in a photo. Choose performance fabrics, sturdy construction, and a cohesive palette. Invest first in the mattresses and the sofa — guests forgive a lot, but not a bad night's sleep.

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| ☐ Sofa & seating in performance fabric | ☐ Quality mattresses — the #1 driver of reviews |
| ☐ Dining seating for full occupancy | ☐ Rugs, side tables, and lamps in every key room |
| ☐ Art & wall decor at the right scale for photos | ☐ Window treatments for light control & privacy |
| ☐ Layered, warm lighting (2700K) + a statement piece | ☐ Accessories & styling — the layer that sells the photo |

03 Stock the Kitchen

Guests notice an under-stocked kitchen immediately. Outfit it like you'd want to cook there: real cookware, enough dishes for full occupancy plus a couple extra, and the small appliances people expect. A great coffee setup is worth its weight in five-star reviews.

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| ☐ Cookware, bakeware, and a good knife set | ☐ Dishes, glasses, mugs & utensils for occupancy +2 |
| ☐ Coffee maker + supplies, kettle, toaster | ☐ Pantry basics: oil, salt & pepper, foil, wrap |
| ☐ Dish soap, dishwasher pods, sponges, towels | ☐ Trash bins + liners in every needed room |

04 Bed & Bath: Hotel-Level Comfort

This is where “nice rental” becomes “I’d stay again.” Two sets of quality linens per bed keep turnovers fast; hotel-grade towels and thoughtful toiletries make the space feel cared for. The little things — extra pillows, a full roll of toilet paper — signal that you sweat the details.

- ☐ **Two sets** of quality linens per bed
- ☐ Bath towels (2+ per guest), hand towels, bath mats
- ☐ Hair dryer, and a stocked supply of toilet paper
- ☐ Extra pillows, blankets, and a throw per bed
- ☐ Shampoo, conditioner, body wash, hand soap
- ☐ Iron, plunger, and a small first-aid kit

05 Amenities That Earn 5 Stars

Amenities are where listings win or lose the comparison. Fast Wi-Fi is non-negotiable, a workspace captures the remote-work crowd, and small touches — a local guide, a welcome treat — turn a good stay into one worth reviewing.

- ☐ Fast, reliable **Wi-Fi** — post the network & password
- ☐ Coffee & tea station
- ☐ Heat, AC, fans, and extra layers for any season
- ☐ Welcome binder / local guide + a small welcome gift
- ☐ Smart TV with streaming
- ☐ A workspace or desk nook
- ☐ Furnished, tidy outdoor space

Drift tip: A dedicated, well-lit workspace quietly expands your market to every remote worker searching your area.

06 Safety & Compliance

Protect your guests and your business. Detectors, extinguishers, and clear emergency info are table stakes — and most cities require a short-term-rental permit, registration, and lodging tax. Check your local rules *before* you list; it's far cheaper than a fine.

- ☐ **Smoke & CO detectors** installed and tested
- ☐ Secure locks / smart lock; exterior lighting
- ☐ Local **STR permit / registration** & lodging tax
- ☐ Fire extinguisher and clearly posted exits
- ☐ House rules & emergency info posted
- ☐ Short-term-rental insurance in place

07 Run It Smoothly

The best-designed rental still needs great operations. A reliable cleaner, a written turnover checklist, and a restock system keep quality consistent across every guest — which is what keeps your rating high.

- ☐ A reliable cleaner & a written turnover checklist
- ☐ Pricing & calendar tool
- ☐ Noise / occupancy monitoring where appropriate
- ☐ A restock system for consumables
- ☐ Saved guest-message templates

08 Before You List

You've built something great — now market it like it. Professional, styled photography is the single highest-ROI thing you can do before going live, paired with an honest, vivid description and competitive pricing for your area.

- ☐ **Professional photos** — staged & styled
- ☐ Complete, accurate amenities list
- ☐ A friendly walkthrough / final quality check
- ☐ A compelling title and honest, vivid description
- ☐ Competitive pricing researched for your area

GET THE FULL GUIDE + FILLABLE TEMPLATES

Ready to go deeper?

Our complete **Airbnb & STR Design Guide** expands on every stage here — with our specific product and vendor recommendations, room-by-room sourcing lists, and **fillable planning templates** you can reuse for every property you set up. It's the whole playbook in one download.

DOWNLOAD ON ETSY

Find it in our Etsy shop — search “Drift Interiors + Architecture.”

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